



IN THE MIDDLE KINGDOM
Left, Akshay Kumar at the shooting of *Selfiee* in Bhopal in 2022; inset, Mani Ratnam at a shoot of *Ponniyin Selvan I* (2022) in Orchha

discovered MP by exploiting its diverse locations, beginning with *Rajneeti* (2008). After this, he shot *Arakshan* (2011), *Chakravyuh* (2012) and *Gangajal 2* (2016) in MP. However, it was the state government's Film Tourism Policy (FTP) in March 2020 that has turned out to be the game-changer. Its most important objective is to facilitate film shootings in MP through a single window system of permissions. This erased the notorious roadblocks that inevitably arise when negotiating a maze of bureaucracy.

The FTP also offers subsidies for content shot in MP, though it covers only a small part of the production cost. Applications for subsidy are to be made post production and it can be claimed only if certain criteria are met, including at least 50 per cent of the project being shot in MP.

But contrary to popular belief, it is not subsidies that are seducing Bollywood biggies. Actually, out of over 400 film shoots since 2020, only 16 have applied for and received the subsidy amount—Rs 2 crore for a film and Rs 1 crore for an OTT. Explains Sheo Shekhar Shukla, principal secretary, tourism and culture, MP: "An important aspect of the film tourism policy is to create an ecosystem for film-making in Madhya Pradesh itself." As part of this, the MP government has identified sites for developing film cities on a public private partnership model in Dewas and Jabalpur. Technical and non-technical training is being imparted for film-related work. "Employment is generated in the process for local youth. Ever since film shooting began in a big way in MP, locals have secured roles as actors in films too," adds Shukla.

One of the biggest results has been the mushrooming of companies that function as line producers for film projects, providing logistics assistance to units from Mumbai such as transport, local actors, location permits, boarding and lodging, security and equipment. "Till 2008, 32 films had been shot in MP. After 2008, the numbers skyrocketed, especially in the past five years," says Syed Zaid Ali, director of Zeal Z Entertainment Services, a Bhopal-based line production company.

Zaid claims his company has handled an astounding 431 film shoots in MP in recent years. "Earlier, films were shot mostly in metros like Mumbai, Chennai and Hyderabad. Later, directors began going to UP and Bihar to get a feel of 'real India'. And they realised that among non-metro options, MP was best in terms of law and order," says Zaid. He also points to the "unmatched" variety of shooting locales in MP: "There are heritage monuments in Khajuraho, Gwalior, Orchha and Mandu, forests in Kanha, Bandhavgharh and Pachmarhi and any village can be a location for a project set in rural India," he adds. Film shoots generate vital revenue for a state—from taxes to hotel bookings. Unsurprisingly, states are competing with each other to get films shot, with Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Gujarat and Andhra Pradesh announcing film policies as well.

Prominent recent projects shot in MP include *Panga* (2020), *Kalank* (2019), *Ludo* (2020), *Mohenjodaro* (2016), *Sanju* (2018), *Stree* (2018), *Stree 2* (2024), *Manikarnika* (2019), *Laapata Ladies* (2023), *Bhool Bhulaiya 3* (2024) and the hit web series *Panchayat* (2020...) and *The Suitable Boy* (2020). *Stree 2*, shot in Chanderi, is the highest grossing Hindi film ever while *Laapata Ladies* is now India's entry to the Oscars. MP is proving to be lucky for film-makers. That's another reason for them to shoot their films in the state. ■

THE GREAT OUTDOORS

- **With over 400 films and OTTs shot in the past four years, MP has emerged as a new hot favourite for Bollywood film-makers**
- **The 2020 Film Tourism Policy, which is putting in place an ecosystem for film-making, has been a game-changer**
- **It is resulting in job creation through production firms, hotel and transport bookings, local actors**
- **The bonus: good tax revenue for the state**